

# Foreword

**T**he history I learned at school was a mass of seemingly endless lists, formed of dates and the names of kings and queens. As a result, I hated it, and never saw the connections between the various strands of the subject. I now realize that history *is* important and that we can all learn from the triumphs—and mistakes—of our ancestors. Both utterly fascinating and hugely informative, *History* is a reference book that teases out the sparks of wars and revolutions, and uncovers the deep roots of great civilizations. It brings the subject to life, painting broad pictures of history's great sweep, aiming to excite and enthuse the reader by focusing on the most interesting, exciting, and dynamic people, events, and ideas of the past.

The photographs, maps, and graphics throughout *History* are spectacular, compelling you to dip in and discover what each page will reveal. This image shows some of the ancient standing stones at Callanish, Scotland, where 20 stone circles jut out from the bare, peaty landscape. The primary purpose of these stones, which have weathered through 4,000 years of human history, seems to have been to mark a curious lunar event that happens only once every 18.61 years—those early astronomers must have been persistent.

One of the joys of this book is that most subjects, however vast in scale, are presented within self-contained spreads. Some describe hundreds of years of ancient Egyptian civilization, or momentous periods of upheaval like the religious Reformation in 17th-century Europe or the Industrial Revolution of the 19th century. Others take as their theme much shorter periods of history, such as the English Civil War or the Russian Revolution. There are also spreads devoted to “Decisive Moments”, key events that proved to be historical turning points, for example the assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand, which triggered World War I, or the 1755 Lisbon earthquake, which shook Europe to its very foundations.

But *History* isn't just about the events that have shaped us. A key strand in the book focuses on the ideas that have changed the world, exploring concepts such as democracy, evolution, and globalization. It also features biographies of some of history's most important and influential individuals from Alexander the Great to Adolf Hitler. And, as an enthusiast of science and technology, I am delighted to see coverage of the crucial innovations, inventions, scientific discoveries, and theories that have had an impact on the human story, from metalworking to the internet, and DNA to global warming.

*Adam Hart-Davis*

ADAM HART-DAVIS

